to shatter the ceiling on its growth imposed by the 50-year stranglehold of the Dravidian parties—the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and its rival, the AIADMK. In June, his comments against the late J. Jayalalithaa, former CM and iconic AIADMK chief, aggravated ties that had already been rendered tenuous by his constant criticism of the AIADMK. Before that, when Jayalalithaa's demise in 2016 left a vacuum in state politics and led to an open struggle for supremacy between AIADMK's current chief, Edappadi K. Palaniswami (EPS) and his predecessor as CM, O. Panneerselvam (OPS), the BJP had moved in to take advantage of the schism. The power that came from being the Goliath at the Centre allowed it to play arbiter, and then a silent big brother. Moving to a less silent mode in pursuit of its expansion plans was natural progression.

Peeved by the young BJP satrap's intemperate remarks and fearing that it might actually be gaining his party mileage at its expense, the AIADMK has in recent months often accused Annamalai of flouting all norms of coalition dharma. The last straw for the AIADMK came on September 11, when Annamalai alleged that the Dravidian icon and former chief minister C.N. Annadurai—the revered 'Anna' who forms part of the party's very name—had insulted Hinduism during an event in Madurai in 1956. Annamalai's earlier allegations of corruption against Jayalalithaa—he later backtracked—had prompted the AIADMK to adopt a resolution describing him as "politically inexperienced and immature". At its Golden Jubilee meet in Madurai on August 20, a decision was taken not to tolerate Annamalai's barbs any longer. On September 18, AIADMK organising secretary D. Jayakumar declared a conditional "separation of ties" with the BJP—an ultimatum for the removal of Annamalai. The final break came after a meeting between



NOT MINCING WORDS Tamil Nadu BJP chief K. Annamalai at a press conference

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FOR ALL ITS POSTURING, THE BJP IS DEPENDENT ON THE AIADMK. THAT'S WHY IT WAS GUARDED IN ITS RESPONSE TO THE SNAP IN TIES

a party delegation and the BJP's leadership in Delhi made it clear that the latter backed Annamalai. "The decision to end the alliance was because of defamatory comments by the BJP state leadership," confirms AIADMK deputy general secretary K.P. Munusamy.

Who is really to blame? "The ego and arrogance arising from political immaturity of Annamalai are substantial factors but the fear of being out of contention in Tamil Nadu politics is the deep fear of the AIADMK that has resulted in the present situation," says political analyst Ramu Manivanna. "It was waiting to happen even before Annamalai," adds political commentator N. Sathiya Moorthy. "After the reversals in the 2019 Lok Sabha and 2021 assembly elections, AIADMK cadres were convinced the BJP's Hindutva politics and perceived anti-minority stand were too costly to bear. Annamalai hastened the process, or provided the pretext the AIADMK needed."

Most experts feel the AIADMK is relieved at getting out of a bad marriage—it hopes to win back some of the minority votes it had lost in 2019 and 2021. It also breaks a narrative the BJP has been crafting sedulously: that Tamil Nadu was a BJP vs DMK contest. A section of the AIADMK genuinely began fearing the prospect of the party being relegated to the third position. Whether that would have happened organically without a split is now a hypothetical question—in actual record, the BJP has been a minor league player in Tamil Nadu, mostly dependent on its local guardian. Even with that, in 2019, it lost in all five Lok Sabha constituencies it contested and could win just four